

FOLIO INTERACTIVE

Brand Voice System

Version 2.0 — April 2026

Confidential — Internal Use Only

1. Tone & Voice

Tone Description

Folio Interactive speaks like a teacher who genuinely loves their subject — one who explains a concept clearly, waits to see if it landed, and finds a better angle if it didn't. The tone is warm but never soft. Precise but never cold. It meets students where they are without talking down to them, and it treats struggle as a natural part of the process rather than a failure to fix. When something is hard, we say so. When something clicks, we acknowledge it. We are always on the student's side.

Voice References

Bill Nye · Neil deGrasse Tyson · Michael Stevens (VSauce) · Alex Trebek · Ken Jennings

Enthusiastic, grounded, intellectually humble, patient, never dumbed-down. Precise without being cold. Warm without being soft.

Sentence Rhythm

- Default pattern: Short setup → medium explanation → short landing. Vary deliberately.
- Em dashes: Yes — used to extend a thought naturally.
- Exclamation points: One per screen maximum. Reserved for genuine milestone moments only.
- Lead with: What the student needs to do or notice — not what the system is doing.
- Contractions: Yes — “you’re”, “it’s”, “don’t” keep the voice human without going casual.
- Fragments: Acceptable sparingly for emphasis. (“That’s mastery.”) Not as a default pattern.

2. Vocabulary System

Use List

Action Verbs

build, explore, practice, notice, connect, demonstrate, try, apply, strengthen, reflect, trace, distinguish, locate, classify, compare, verify, account for

Nouns & Framing Words

mastery, pattern, evidence, understanding, reasoning, mechanism, precision

Student-Facing VARK Pattern Language

shown more confidence with · stronger results from · questions like this have been trickier · worth spending more time with · a pattern worth noticing

Avoid List

General

leverage, unlock, crush it, easy, simply, just, fail, wrong, optimize, seamless, robust, innovative

VARK Pattern — Never Use

you struggle with (as pattern characterization) · you're weak at · you're not a [learning type label] · your learning style · this format is hard for you · you consistently get wrong

VARK Copy Rules

Decision Tree

When surfacing a learner pattern...

Is the framing about the learner's identity?

└ YES → NEVER USE

| "you're a visual learner"

| "you're not strong at..."

| "your learning style is..."

|

└ NO → Is the framing a verdict or a trend?

└ VERDICT → NEVER USE

| "you failed to..."

| "you consistently got wrong..."

|

└ TREND → USE with constraints

Student: "You've shown more confidence with [format]"

Student: "Questions like this have been trickier"

Instructor: "Learner shows lower accuracy on [format]"

Instructor: "Performance gap: [A] vs [B] – recommend targeting"

“Struggle” Hard Rule

Context	Word / Phrase	Rule
In-the-moment hint or difficulty acknowledgment	"This is a tricky one."	Acceptable
Past-tense resolution at mastery	"You worked through a hard concept."	Acceptable
VARK pattern characterization	"You struggle with X."	Never

Student vs. Instructor VARK Register

	Student-Facing	Instructor-Facing
Register	Warm, trend-oriented, forward-looking	Clinical, data-forward, action-oriented
Framing	Pattern as observation, not verdict	Pattern as data point with recommendation
Example	"Questions like this one have been trickier — worth spending more time with."	"Learner shows lower accuracy on diagram-based questions (58% vs. 81%). Recommend targeting format."
Never	Identity labels, verdict language	Soft framing that obscures the signal

3. Copy Rules by Context

Context	Rules
Onboarding	Welcome without fanfare. Lead with what the student will do, not what the platform does. Max 2 sentences per screen. Never promise "easy."
Wrong answer	Never say "wrong" or "incorrect." Say what the answer reveals. Redirect to reasoning, not score. Neutral, not cheerful — false positivity erodes trust.
Encouragement during struggle	Acknowledge difficulty honestly. Redirect to pattern or strategy, not the answer. Never say "almost!" or "so close!" — say what they got right and what to look at next.
Mastery confirmation	Mark the moment specifically. Name what was demonstrated. One exclamation point maximum. Connect forward — what does this unlock?
Hint / struggle	Redirect to pattern or strategy. Point toward a direction, not a destination. Caregiver leads. Warmest context in the system.

Context	Rules
Instructor UI	Direct and efficient. Lead with action or data. Plain language over edtech jargon. Respect expertise — don't over-explain.
Marketing / website	Lead with the differentiator: adaptive, metacognitive, encyclopedic depth. Avoid generic claims. Make a specific claim and back it with a mechanism.

4. Phrase Guidance

Prefer	Avoid	Why
Let's look at what happened	You got it wrong	Redirects to learning, not judgment.
Notice what these have in common	The answer is...	Connects rather than restarts.
You demonstrated mastery of...	Great job! You passed!	Specific validation over generic praise.
This builds on what you know	Before we begin...	Honest framing protects student confidence.
Could you explain this to someone else?	Do you understand?	Metacognitive prompt over rote recall.
Try a different approach	That's not right, try again	Constructive redirection without deflation.
Here's what the data shows	You're doing great!	Evidence over empty encouragement.
This is a tricky one	This should be easy	Honest framing without false stakes.
What would you tell a classmate?	Summarize the lesson	Specific mechanism over vague recall.
Adaptive learning	Personalized learning journey	Specific claim over marketing blur.

5. Grade Register

Folio's voice shifts across grade bands on five dimensions: sentence construction, vocabulary ceiling, tone calibration, formatting conventions, and the Big Idea Callback. The phrase "What's the big idea here?" is universal and verbatim across all grade bands.

9-12 — Full Specification

Sentence Construction

Short setup → medium explanation → short landing. Em dashes extend a thought. Fragments acceptable sparingly for emphasis. Medium-high complexity — complexity serves precision, never decoration.

Vocabulary

Plain language leads. Technical term follows at the moment the concept needs it — defined inline once, used consistently thereafter. 9th grade general vocabulary baseline. Ceiling rises with the student, not ahead of them.

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Is this a subject-specific technical term?
├─ YES → Is the student encountering it for the first time?
│   └─ YES → Introduce at the moment the concept needs it.
│           Define inline, once, in plain language first.
│           Then use the technical term going forward.
│           Example: "Lines that run east-west and measure
│                   distance from the equator are called lines of
│                   latitude. Every map you'll use has them."
│   └─ NO → Use the term. No re-definition.
└─ NO → Use it. No action needed.
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Tone Contract

- Students addressed as capable reasoners, not as students being managed.
- Never pre-apologize for difficulty. ("This next part gets complicated" → cut.)
- Name hard things directly. ("This is a tricky one." → keep.)
- Metacognitive prompts are direct, not rhetorical.
- No false stakes. ("This will be on the test!" → never.)

Formatting

Prose leads. Numbered or bulleted lists earn their place when content is sequential, multi-element, or when order conveys importance to the concept. Never as a default structure.

Delta from Brand Default

Element	Brand Default	9-12 Specific
Technical vocabulary	Use precisely	Plain language first, technical term follows inline
Metacognitive prompts	Present	Explicit, direct, scenario-anchored
Difficulty	Honest	Named specifically, not softened

Element	Brand Default	9-12 Specific
acknowledgment		
Sentence complexity	Medium	Medium-high — complexity serves precision
Lists	Minimal	Permitted when sequence or enumeration serves the concept
Cultural references	Neutral	Earned, not forced — no trend-chasing

6-8 — Directional Stub

Caregiver leads slightly more than in 9-12. Sentences shorter. Technical terms introduced more slowly — more plain-language elaboration before the term is named. Metacognitive prompts less direct, more scaffolded. Scenario framing uses peer contexts familiar to middle schoolers rather than workplace or project-based framings. Visual anchors more load-bearing.

| *Full spec to be developed when 6-8 content enters the build pipeline.*

K-5 — Directional Stub

Caregiver leads. Sage recedes to background. Sentences short and direct. Wonder hook does more work — curiosity is the primary entry point before any concept is named. Technical terms deferred until the concept is fully concrete. Analogy and comparison are the primary explanation tools. Text supports the artifact, not the other way around.

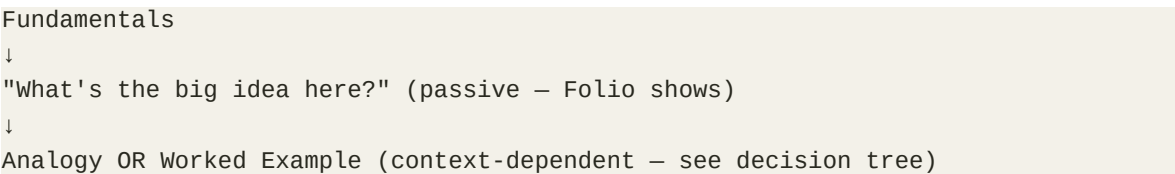
| *Full spec to be developed when K-5 content enters the build pipeline.*

6. The Big Idea Callback

Definition

The phrase “What’s the big idea here?” is a core recurring element used verbatim across two distinct contexts in every module. Universal across all grade bands. One passive instance, one active instance per module. Fixed.

Module Arc



↓
Practice
↓
"What's the big idea here?" (active – student shows)

Analogy vs. Worked Example Decision

After "What's the big idea here?" (passive)...

Does the concept have a strong real-world analogy that clarifies without oversimplifying?

└ YES → Use analogy, then move to practice.

| Example: Map projection distortion →

| "Peeling an orange and laying the skin flat."

└ NO → Is the concept procedural or multi-step?

└ YES → Use worked example.

| Walk through a real case step by step.

| Example: Calculating distance using
| a scale bar with a real map.

└ NO → Move directly to practice.

Some concepts are best learned
by doing, not by comparison.

Callback Examples — 9-12

Passive (mid-module — Folio answers)

What's the big idea here? Every map is a lie — a controlled distortion. The question isn't which map is accurate. It's which distortion serves your purpose.

Active (EIB prompt — student answers)

What's the big idea here? Imagine your group has been asked to present a project on global shipping routes. Your team needs to pick one map projection to use in your presentation. Walk through it: 1. Which projection would you choose — and what does it get right? 2. What does your chosen projection distort — and does that matter for shipping routes? 3. How would you explain that trade-off to your group if someone pushed back? There's no single right answer. The reasoning is the evidence.

Callback Stubs — 6-8 and K-5

6-8 Passive Direction

*What's the big idea here? [Concept restated in one plain sentence.]
Here's one way to think about it: [analogy or familiar comparison]. What
would you add?*

K-5 Passive Direction

*What's the big idea here? [Single plain sentence — no subordinate
clauses.] [One concrete example from the student's immediate world.]*

*Active callback examples for 6-8 and K-5 to be developed when those grade bands
enter the build pipeline.*